

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Preparedness on a limited budget

PREPAREDNESS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Start with a household plan, written contacts and supplies you already own. Prioritize drinking water, essential medicines, food you normally eat and safe light. Build gradually without taking money away from urgent household needs.

Do now.

- ☐ **Inventory before buying**
01 Check usable water containers, lights, batteries, food, clothing and charging options. Record quantities, expiry dates and gaps.
- ☐ **Choose one realistic priority**
02 Match the first purchase to a likely disruption and a person's essential need. A medicine or water gap matters more than specialist gadgets.
- ☐ **Build into normal routines**
03 Add a small amount of shelf-stable food or water when affordable. Rotate what the household actually uses and can prepare safely.
- ☐ **Make free planning changes**
04 Write emergency contacts, choose meeting places, save guides and learn safe shutoffs. Practice an exit route and check warning access.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Plan around actual carrying capacity, storage, transport and money. Identify safe mutual support before a crisis, but confirm what a neighbor or group can provide. A borrowed item is only useful when it will be accessible during the disruption.

Watch for.

Do not buy unsafe used safety equipment, store fuel improperly or ration essential medication to build a kit. No shopping list guarantees survival.

People & practical needs.

Ask each person what they need to function without power or transport. Include sensory access, infant feeding, pets and medical routines. Keep a written priority list so shared household purchases solve a real problem rather than duplicating equipment.

Keep essentials within reach.

Keep the action checklist and written contact details accessible. Use the equipment named in this guide only when available and appropriate. Assign someone to check access, batteries and expiry dates before an incident; retrieving a kit must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Revisit one gap at a time. Check a kit when food or medication rotates, after household changes and before the local hazard season.

Little storage space

Choose compact supplies that are useful in daily life, keep exits clear and identify a safe storage location.

No purchase is affordable now

Complete contacts, escape planning, guide saving and a household inventory first. Ask a trusted local support group about verified resources when safe.

Questions in the field.

Do I need a large commercial kit?

No. Start with practical needs and equipment the household can use. Compare an actual inventory with the likely disruption before buying.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

INCIDENT / SYMPTOM ONSET / LOCATION

HELP REQUESTED / RESPONSE CONFIRMED

ACTIONS / TIMES / NEXT HANDOVER

Sources & limits.

Civilian household planning. U.S. references; local conditions, services and building procedures differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

[Ready.gov – Low and no-cost preparedness](#)

<https://www.ready.gov/low-and-no-cost>

[Ready.gov – Build a kit](#)

<https://www.ready.gov/kit>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/preparedness/budget-preparedness/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.